

# WINAMP TO SHUT DOWN, LLAMAS REJOICE!

**After “whooping the llama’s ass” for 16 years, AOL has announced that it will be closing down Winamp (and its related services) on December 20. End of an era?**

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An immensely cherished link to our collective digital past, by means of a software dating back to the ‘90s and the early days of the Internet, is being severed; and it isn’t unlike the cutting of a umbilical cord – digitally at least. Winamp, the fodder of every music hoarder who ever existed and the butt of several llama jokes, is soon to be discontinued. After December 20, there’ll be no more of Winamp. If that isn’t tear-jerkingly emotional, we don’t know what is.

Winamp still remains one of the most popular music players on desktops but ever since the advent of the iPod and iTunes and the more recent emergence of streaming players like Spotify, user share has dipped. In 2004, Nullsoft, the developer of Winamp, was bought by AOL for \$80 million. Even now, Winamp is said to generate about \$6 million of revenue annually for AOL, so the reason behind the decision to shut it down remains a strange one.

The first version of Winamp (0.2a) was launched in 1997 as freeware by Justin Frankel and Dmitry Boldyrev with a focus on minimalism and MP3 playback. Winamp continued to evolve and soon after v2.0 released, it quickly became one of the most downloaded software on Windows. Winamp3 was released in 2002, following which in 2003, Winamp 5, the biggest visual

change in the player’s history (and the final ‘major’ version upgrade), was launched. Winamp v5.66 was recently released, and will probably be the final official update for the music player.

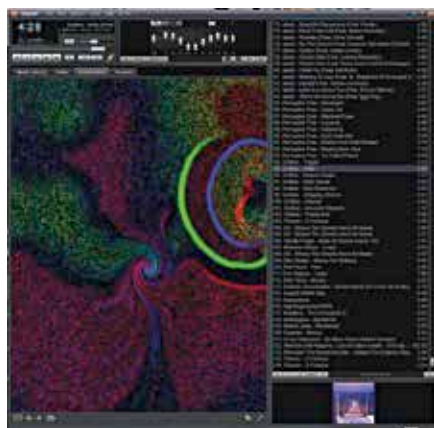
However, since Winamp is primarily an offline software, you can continue to use it, just make sure you download and keep a copy of the installer safely backed up and tucked away. Although we’re sure there will be a million sites out there from which you could continue to download the installer, even if the official source shuts down. Updates aren’t too big an issue since Winamp users are accustomed to getting very rare updates, maybe once a year. However, the death of official support could mean that Winamp users may be

left out in the cold if incompatibilities with any future versions of Windows should arise. One way this could be dealt with is if the Winamp source code is released; although, considering AOL’s background, that seems unlikely.

On a personal note, some of us have been using Winamp since our schooldays back in 1999 and still continue to use it everyday. Despite owning an iPhone, we continue to use Winamp because in our experience iTunes on Windows is probably one of the worst things that Apple’s name has ever been associated with. If you have a large music collection, an obsession with ID3 tags, album artwork and organising your music, you’ll be hard-pressed to come across a better music player to help sort everything out. Unless Windows forces us to stop using Winamp, we’ll continue using it, but the experience would feel incomplete with the people behind it no longer there.

## 5 great (free) alternatives to Winamp

Now that Winamp is officially being shut down by AOL, many of you must have already begun looking for a new music player to call your own. Well, stop, because we’ve done the hard work for you. While you can continue using Winamp, if you do want to step away from the player and look at other desktop



Winamp and its visualisations